

Invitation to a Wedding

A Homily on Sukkot as Encounter

Ayal Klein

And the LORD spoke unto Moses, saying: Speak unto the children of Israel, saying: On the fifteenth day of this seventh month is the Feast of Tabernacles, seven days unto the LORD. On the first day shall be a holy convocation; you shall do no manner of servile work. Seven days you shall bring an offering made by fire unto the LORD; on the eighth day shall be a holy convocation unto you, and you shall bring an offering made by fire unto the LORD; it is a solemn assembly; you shall do no manner of servile work.

These are the appointed seasons of the LORD, which you shall proclaim to be holy convocations, to bring an offering made by fire unto the LORD — burnt-offering and meal-offering, sacrifice and drink-offerings, each on its own day; besides the sabbaths of the LORD, and besides your gifts, and besides all your vows, and besides all your freewill-offerings, which you give unto the LORD.

But on the fifteenth day of the seventh month, when you have gathered in the produce of the land, you shall keep the feast of the LORD seven days; on the first day shall be a solemn rest, and on the eighth day shall be a solemn rest. And you shall take on the first day the fruit of goodly trees, branches of palm-trees, and boughs of thick trees, and willows of the brook, and you shall rejoice before the LORD your God seven days. And you shall keep it a feast unto the LORD seven days in the year; it is a statute forever throughout your generations; you shall keep it in the seventh month. You shall dwell in booths seven days; all that are home-born in Israel shall dwell in booths, that your generations may know that I made the children of Israel to dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt: I am the LORD your God.

Leviticus 23:33–43

The portion of the Feast of Tabernacles (Sukkot) appears at the end of the passage on the appointed seasons in the book of Leviticus. That passage (Lev. 23) opens with Passover, moves through the counting of the Omer to the Feast of Weeks, then commands Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, and finally arrives at the verses above, which deal with the command concerning the Feast of Tabernacles.

One can see that, in the middle of the section dealing with Sukkot, there appears what looks like the closing of the passage on the appointed seasons.[1] After this closing, a "second Sukkot

passage" appears — the Torah returns and commands, once again, a seven-day festival on the fifteenth of the seventh month, at whose end — on the eighth day — there is a further festival. This duplication is very striking, and it raises a sharp question at the level of the plain sense of the text. From the style of the text, it appears that each sub-passage on Sukkot stands on its own, and yet both deal with the very same festival.

Following our own approach, we will explain this duplication as teaching us about an essential duality in the character of the Feast of Tabernacles. The Torah describes the Feast of Tabernacles twice because, in its very essence, it is a "double" festival, a festival with two faces. The reason for the festival's twofold essence lies in its belonging to two different festival systems, to two annual cycles at once. Sukkot is both part of the system of agricultural festivals — the three pilgrimage festivals (Shalosh Regalim) — and part of the system of the festivals of the seventh month.[2]

Further evidence for the double affiliation of the Feast of Tabernacles can be found in the tally of the festival sacrifices. Let us present the tally of festival sacrifices, according to Numbers, chapters 28–29:

Festival	Lambs	Rams	Bulls
Passover	7	1	2
Shavuot	7	1	2
Rosh Hashanah	7	1	1
Yom Kippur	7	1	1
Sukkot	14	2	13–7

This presentation of the sacrifice tally offers further support for the claim that two festival systems exist — we see that the sacrifice tally for Passover is identical to that of Shavuot, and likewise that the sacrifice tally for Rosh Hashanah is identical to that of Yom Kippur. Beyond this, one can see directly that Sukkot is presented as a doubled festival — both in the tally of lambs and in the tally of rams. It is specifically in the tally of bulls — which, according to the table, is what determines a festival's affiliation with one of the two festival systems — that the Torah, as it were, removes Sukkot from the game. This fact can be interpreted in one of two ways — either Sukkot belongs to neither system, and stakes out a category of its own, or it belongs to both, and therefore cannot fit into either of the two defined patterns.[3] Our claim is that both possibilities are true — that is, Sukkot indeed belongs fully both to the system of agricultural festivals and to the system of the festivals of the seventh month, and this very fact is what expresses its uniqueness, setting it apart from the rest of the festivals.

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Meeting of Axes

The essence of Sukkot does not end with its double affiliation; we wish to argue that the Feast of Tabernacles constitutes a meeting between two axes, and, in fact, a summation and closing of the entire system of Torah festivals. What is the meaning of this meeting?

In order to understand the depth of the matter, let us first deal with each axis in its own right. Once we understand the meaning of each festival system, and decipher its axis of progression, we will be able to grasp the character of Sukkot as the point where these two courses intersect.

A. The Course of the Agricultural Festivals — Nature Ascends toward Divinity

The concern of the agricultural festivals is to raise nature up toward divinity. This is expressed in the central commandment that binds these three festivals together — the pilgrimage (aliyah la-regel). The very ethos of pilgrimage expresses the sense that there is a mundane life, a life lived within the country, which, once in a while — for the sake of its spiritual sustenance and its bond to the divine — must go up to the mountain of the LORD, to the place of holiness, set apart and sublime.

One can view the pilgrimage festivals as a course, as a progressive sequence. The agricultural aspect of each festival can be seen mainly in the distinctly agricultural commandments — the waving of the Omer, the two loaves, and the four species. On Passover we bring the meal-offering of the Omer, made from barley flour. Barley, as is well known, is animal fodder.[4] On Shavuot we bring the two loaves, made of wheat flour, which is human food. On Sukkot we take the four species — the fruit of a goodly tree, palm branches, boughs of a thick tree, and willows of the brook. What they share is that they are not grain crops at all, but fruits — the food of the Garden of Eden.[5] We see that nature itself is elevated, refined, and with each festival we bring a higher kind of food.

A further layer of this elevation is the action we are asked to perform with the agricultural yield. The meal-offering of the Omer we take a handful of, offering that handful upon the altar, while the rest is eaten by the priests, as with any meal-offering. The two loaves are brought up onto the altar and waved before the LORD, but they are eaten whole. The four species we wave before the LORD throughout the country, thereby pleasing the Holy One with an offering even outside the bounds of the Temple. This difference expresses a gradation in the manner by which the mundane is bound to the holy. At the lowest, most primary level, the mundane must be bound and offered up from within itself, setting apart a portion of itself unto the absolute holy in order to become legitimate. At the next level, there is no need to relinquish or take merely a handful from any side or force of the mundane realm; it suffices to wave it at the altar, to place it within the domain of the holy. One must, indeed, display the name "offering," expressing the belonging to the sublime and exalted holy — but afterward the priests are permitted to eat the whole of the bread.[6] At the final level, expressed in the commandment of taking the four species,[7] we do not even display the name "offering"; we are not obligated to bring the fruits up to the Temple. We take them and wave them, rejoicing in them before the LORD in every place. The fruits serve for an experience of rejoicing in God, of nearness to God, yet they do not become "consecrated objects," and are even permitted for eating and use after the festival.[8]

This difference in the manner of "offering," or of binding to the holy, likewise expresses the refinement of nature, its advance toward the supreme divine source.

B. The Course of the Seventh-Month Festivals — Divinity Descends into the World

The festivals of the seventh month are not focused on performing an "act of offering" from the agricultural yield, as the pilgrimage festivals are. The human action in these festivals is, for the most part, passive — hearing the shofar, fasting; and Sukkot, too, has such an aspect, if we focus our gaze on the commandment of dwelling in the sukkah. From this one can infer that the main activity taking place is not a movement of human being, but rather its response to various revelatory manifestations of the divine.

Rosh Hashanah is a day of God's appearance in judgment. God is revealed on the earth, and this revelation is, first of all, an appearance of might, of judgment —

You have said: It is vain to serve God; and: What profit is it that we have kept His charge... Then they that feared the LORD spoke one with another; and the LORD hearkened, and heard, and a book of remembrance was written before Him, for them that feared the LORD, and that thought upon His name. And they shall be Mine, saith the LORD of hosts, in the day that I do make, even Mine own treasure... Then shall you again discern between the righteous and the wicked, between him that serves God and him that serves Him not... For behold, the day comes, it burns as a furnace; and all the proud, and all that work wickedness, shall be stubble, and the day that comes shall set them ablaze...

Malachi 3:14-19

God's appearance on earth, in contrast to a period of the hiding of the Face, is described in terms of the calling-in of the debts of the wicked, and of compassion toward one who has vindicated himself in judgment. We relate to Rosh Hashanah as the "Day of the LORD"[9]; we gird ourselves with awe, and sound the "blast of the King," inasmuch as God stands over us, King over all the earth, the rod of judgment in His hand.[10]

On Yom Kippur the Holy One appears to us in the attribute of mercy. Mercy expresses a vacating of space by God for the sake of man, a contraction (tzimtzum). God is revealed as "slow to anger." "Slowness to anger" does not mean granting legitimacy to sin and to the sinning person, but rather the postponement of judgment, the divine capacity to conquer anger, to restrain the swift, immediate verdict. This divine retreat finds expression in the granting of credit to the sinner, so that he has time and opportunity to repent, to correct himself, before the appearance of divine judgment on earth.

"For on this day shall atonement be made for you, to cleanse you; from all your sins shall you be clean before the LORD."[11] The service of Yom Kippur is the granting of permission by God for

man to atone for himself, to the point of permission to enter the Holy of Holies. The revelation is still situated in the place of the holy, in God's own house; except that God contracts Himself and permits an extraordinary entry by man into this place that does not belong to him — "and the cloud of incense shall cover the ark-cover that is upon the testimony, that he not die." [12] God, as it were, restrains Himself and clears a path within His presence, which otherwise fills every place, leaving no room for anyone else, [13] for the sake of the priest atoning on behalf of the people.

By contrast, on Sukkot the divine manifestation takes the form of the clouds of glory — "for I made the children of Israel dwell in booths, when I brought them out of the land of Egypt." The place where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) rests is not the house of God, but rather precisely a temporary dwelling belonging to man, outside the holy. The desired psychic posture is neither awe and dread (as on Rosh Hashanah) nor supplication and the seeking of pardon (as on Yom Kippur), but joy — "and you shall rejoice in your feast... and you shall be altogether joyful." [14] Man is commanded to live in the sukkah, and the Shekhinah that crowns it does not negate natural existence, which includes eating, drinking and sleeping. The sukkah is a mediating space, in which man indeed stands beneath the sky, yet "its shade is greater than its sun" — the supernal divine light sends its rays inward, but does not burn or consume, and thereby allows man a dwelling place in which the Shekhinah may rest. The desired human action is neither silent listening (hearing the sound of the shofar) nor active self-affliction ("you shall afflict your souls"), but rather that same natural, everyday human activity, set within a context of holiness, joy and festivity.

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A Canopy of Clouds of Glory

We find, then, that on Sukkot two processes with complementary directions reach their culmination — divinity gradually descends into the world, while, in parallel, the world and man are refined and elevated toward divinity. This is the Torah's own description of a process of marriage — each party leaves its own place to move toward the other, and only after a process in which, on the one hand, each advances toward the other, and, on the other hand, each clears an inner space to let the other in, can complete union take place. The Feast of Tabernacles is shaped as the wedding celebration of the Holy One with man (or with existence), and the sukkah is shaped in the image of the wedding canopy (chuppah). In order to substantiate this claim, let us first sketch the concept of the chuppah, in light of ancient custom and halakha.

From the fact that our sages did not explain, clarify or define what the chuppah is, but rather related to this concept as a given, we learn that it was, apparently, a widespread and agreed-upon custom (and, quite possibly, a very ancient one as well [15]). It therefore seems that the chuppah is not a halakhic concept created in the study hall and then imposed upon reality, but rather the reverse — it was the practice that expressed and enacted marriage, and, as a result, halakha related to it as such. It refers to a kind of decorated pavilion or chamber, [16] which

constitutes the place of the first seclusion (yichud) of the bride and groom.[17] This was their first shared dwelling, both in terms of property[18] and in terms of actual residence. The custom was to decorate the chuppah before the entry of the bride and groom.[19] The seven days following the entry into the chuppah are called "the seven days of the feast,"[20] and they take place within the chuppah, with the community holding joyous feasts together with the bride and groom inside the chuppah.[21]

The chuppah is described as a modest, pleasant, romantic and intimate place of seclusion. The betrothed man and woman, who had already been set apart for one another for some time, enter their new home together, and thereby become husband and wife. The wedding celebration was the public event in which the bride and groom entered the chuppah together (called "bringing in the bride"). The seven days of the chuppah were devoted both to public rejoicing, at the time of the feasts and the recitation of the "Seven Blessings," and to the private, intimate joy of the bride and groom with one another.[22]

One can thus see a clear overlap and a close connection between the descriptions of the chuppah and the descriptions of the sukkah[23] — both constitute a kind of temporary dwelling, both are customarily decorated, and both are set apart for seven days of rejoicing, in which one sits and eats and celebrates precisely within them. The Feast of Tabernacles is the wedding celebration of God with man, held in the special chuppah that man has built for this very purpose. God spreads His Shekhinah over man, shelters him, protects him and dwells with him — "for I made the children of Israel dwell in booths — they were clouds of glory" (Sukkah 11b). The shared dwelling of man and the Holy One in the sukkah constitutes the essential joy of the festival, and it is the intended purpose of religious life as a whole — the capacity to live in devotion (deveikut) with God.

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A Life of Divine Inspiration

Let us, then, try to complete the picture.

Sukkot, as noted above, is "the festival of the ingathering" (Chag ha-Asif) — not only in the sense of the closing of the agricultural year (which constitutes its essence on the axis of the pilgrimage festivals), nor merely as a chronological conclusion, by virtue of being the last festival on the Hebrew calendar, but also as a closing in the spiritual sense. It is the final result, the conclusion, the ripe, finished fruit of the entire system of Torah festivals.

After a process in which, on the one hand, divinity has "contracted" itself and allowed room for a natural, "mundane" human existence, and, on the other hand, man has learned to raise up the abundance he has received, and the mundane realm in which he lives, to the level of a kind of "offering," without thereby nullifying the joy, the delight and the vigor of life within it — man and God are able to dwell under one roof, to be included one within the other, and to be united. The climactic point of the festivals is not religious ecstasy — neither the sense of purification of

Yom Kippur, nor the sense of redemption and deliverance of Passover. The festivals conclude, precisely, in the celebration of the seven days of Sukkot, precisely in a "soft," refined joy — a joy of what lies within life itself: joy in abundance, in the harvest, and in domesticity with God. This domesticity is, by its nature, everyday, and so too is the experience of holiness^[24] of Sukkot — the joy of the commandment present in every meal, in every sleep and in every act of sitting, in every mundane conversation and in every simple conduct of life.^[25] We give thanks for the blessing with which God blesses us, a blessing that rests upon life itself, sweetening it and giving it its fragrance.

This joy, we carry onward into life.

Notes

1. Verse 37 parallels, and clearly refers back to, verse 2 at the beginning of the passage: "Speak unto the children of Israel, and say unto them: The appointed seasons of the LORD, which you shall proclaim to be holy convocations, even these are My appointed seasons."
2. The claim that the festivals of the seventh month are bound together into one overarching system can be reinforced by several arguments. One argument is conceptual — we recognize the principle of the number seven as expressing the sanctity of time — the Sabbath of creation, the Sabbatical year, the Jubilee — and so it stands to reason that on the monthly plane, too, the seventh month carries special significance. Another argument is textual — both in the Yom Kippur passage and in the Sukkot passage, the phrase "this seventh month" appears, weaving these two appointed times together with that same seventh month mentioned in the Rosh Hashanah passage.
3. It should be noted that we do not understand the content of the deviation itself. It is possible that the setting of the festival's bulls as a descending tally from day to day, from 13 down to 7 bulls per day, expresses some idea about the essence of the festival unrelated to its character as a double festival — such as, for example, our sages' suggestion of 70 bulls corresponding to the 70 nations of the world, and the like.
4. Yerushalmi, Beitzah, ch. 1, halakha 11.
5. So it appears from the plain sense of the text, inasmuch as part of the curse for Adam's sin is the eating of "the herb of the field." So too Ibn Ezra writes (on Gen. 3:18): "And the meaning of 'the herb of the field' is bread. For in the garden his sustenance was from the fruit of the tree. And the meaning of 'by the sweat of your brow' is that he must now labor to winnow and grind and knead and bake..."
6. One can compare this to the various ways of fulfilling "know Him in all your ways." The first way is to dedicate specific stretches of time to the commandments, to Torah and to prayer, thereby turning them into a kind of extraterritorial zone cut off from mundane life by virtue of being "holy" — yet in this way projecting onto the mundane realm its principled bond to the holy. The second way is the consciousness of intention for the sake of Heaven, by which every act — even a discretionary act — is essentially bound to the holy, to Torah and the commandments, and thereby acquires its value.
7. For the conception that the commandment of taking the lulav is a kind of offering — which allows placing it on a common comparative axis together with the Omer offering and the two loaves — there are several halakhic hints. See, for example, the words of Ba'al ha-Maor (Sukkah 14b in the Rif's pagination), who explains the prohibition against taking a dried-out lulav throughout the seven days by way of the verse "Present it now unto your governor" (Malachi 1:8), which deals with bringing blemished animals as offerings to the Temple. Likewise, the manner of the waving we perform with the lulav recalls the waving performed with some of the meal-offerings (see Sukkah 38a). Even the phrase commanding rejoicing before the LORD ("and you shall take for yourselves on the first day... and you shall rejoice before the LORD your God") is a phrase we otherwise recognize in the Torah only in contexts connected to the Temple.
8. If we continue the analogy of "know Him in all your ways," this final level — expressed in the four species — expresses an entirely different way of fulfilling "know Him in all your ways." In this way, life itself stands at so high and valuable a level, is so directed, in its very being, toward the supreme good, that there is no need to bind the discretionary, mundane act to the holy and to the Torah, and no need to justify it by its instrumental value to the service of the commandments. Life itself is illuminated by the light of the service of God, with no need to bind it to a separate holy.

9. One can see that our sages drew their anthropomorphic images regarding Rosh Hashanah from the depiction of the LORD's light in this chapter of the book of Malachi — God's book of remembrance, which distinguishes between the righteous and the wicked, and in which man's deeds are recorded. So too regarding the obligation to repent before the coming of the Day of the LORD, which establishes Elul as days of repentance.

10. The hearing of the sound of the shofar carries a double meaning. On the one hand, the sounding of the shofar is an act of coronation, by which man establishes God as sovereign and supreme King; on the other hand, man is struck dumb before the sound of the shofar, thereby reenacting the experience of the revelation at Mount Sinai — "and there were thunders and lightnings, and a thick cloud upon the mount, and the voice of a horn exceeding loud; and all the people that were in the camp trembled" (Ex. 19:16).

11. Lev. 16:30.

12. Ibid., v. 13.

13. Compare: "Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. And Moses was not able to enter into the tent of meeting, because the cloud abode thereon, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle" (Ex. 40:34–35).

14. Deut. 16:15. It is true that on Shavuot, too, the command to rejoice is mentioned, but only on Sukkot is there an emphasis on the exclusivity of the feeling of joy — "and you shall be altogether joyful."

15. Already in the Bible we find a reference to the chuppah in a manner similar to its treatment in the period of the Tannaim — "Blow the horn in Zion, sanctify a fast, call a solemn assembly; gather the people, sanctify the congregation... let the bridegroom go forth from his chamber, and the bride out of her canopy (chuppah)" (Joel 2:15–16); "which is as a bridegroom coming out of his chamber (chuppah)" (Ps. 19:6 — a psalm written by David).

16. See, for example: "...like a king who was marrying off his son and made him a chuppah, plastered it, paneled it and decorated it..." (Genesis Rabbah [Theodor-Albeck], 28, s.v. "me-adam ad behemah").

17. The essence of the chuppah lies in the consummation of the marital relationship — "everyone knows why a bride enters the chuppah, but whoever disgraces his mouth and utters a vulgar word..." (Ketubot 8b). Hence one finds many halakhic discussions on the status of a chuppah without consummation, or of a chuppah unfit for consummation. See, for example, Mishnah Eduyot 8:2; Tosefta Yevamot 10:2; Sanhedrin 57b; and elsewhere.

18. From certain sources we see that the chuppah belongs to the groom, and the bride is the one who "passes into his domain" (leaving "her father's house" and entering "her husband's house" — see Num. 30:7, 11; and see Yerushalmi Nedarim 10:1). By contrast, there are sources in which the chuppah is related more to the bride (see Genesis Rabbah [Theodor-Albeck], parashah 9, s.v. "vayar Elohim"; and cf. Vayikra Rabbah [Vilna], parashah 9:6).

19. Masechet Semachot 8:2: "One makes chuppahs for grooms and brides, and one may hang in them both things that contain food and things that do not contain food... These are the things one may hang in them — nuts... strips of purple wool, and small bottles, and flasks of perfumed oil... the general rule is: whatever is hung in the chuppah is forbidden for benefit."

20. Ketubot 3b. See also Otzar ha-Midrashim [Eisenstein], p. 319, s.v. "ma'aseh be-Rabbi," where these days are called "the seven days of the chuppah."

21. See Sukkah 25b, where the groom and "the groomsmen and all the people of the chuppah" are exempted from eating in the sukkah, since "there is no joy except in the place of the feast" and "there is no joy except in the chuppah."

22. See the following description: "A certain man used to say, Tomorrow I shall sit with my betrothed in the chuppah and cling to her... And so he did — he entered the chuppah with his betrothed and sat with her the whole day, and at night the two of them went up to bed, and before he could be intimate with his betrothed, they both died..." (Otzar ha-Midrashim [Eisenstein], p. 35, s.v. "kalta alta").

23. See also the linguistic parallel: "And the LORD will create over the whole habitation of Mount Zion, and over her assemblies, a cloud and smoke by day, and the shining of a flaming fire by night; for over all the glory shall be a canopy (chuppah). And there shall be a booth (sukkah) for a shadow in the daytime from the heat, and for a refuge and covert from storm and from rain" (Isaiah 4:5–6).

24. It is possible that the precise word in this context is not "holiness" (kedushah) but "glory" (kavod). Kavod, which recalls the clouds of glory of the Sukkot of the Exodus from Egypt, expresses the immanent divine presence within being — "the whole earth is full of His glory" (Isaiah 6:3).

25. One should compare the proper conduct in the sukkah to that required in a synagogue. Synagogues, owing to their sanctity, "one does not behave in them with levity... and one does not eat in them, nor drink in them, nor sleep in them, nor stroll about in them" (Tosefta Megillah [Lieberman], ch. 2, halakha 18). In order to establish sanctity, we must push out anything expressing the mundane, easygoing sides of life. In the sukkah, by contrast, we are commanded in precisely these things — "he makes it his principal dwelling, and eats, drinks, sleeps and strolls about in it" (Tur, Orach Chaim 639). The divine presence in the sukkah is found even within the very lightness of spirit.